

HASHKAMA WEEKLY

פרשת ויקרא
ב' ניסן תשפ"ו
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חכמה ב-א תאמין?

By Reb Gemini

Consider the following "Torah" thought, generated by Gemini: Did the AI get it right? Do you find it to be accurate? Or did the technology miss the boat?

In Parshas Vayikra, the Torah details various korbanos (sacrifices). Most involve expensive livestock, but Vayikra 2:1 introduces the Korban Minchah (meal offering): "And when a nefesh (soul) brings a meal offering to Hashem..." Rashi (Rabbi Shlomo Yitzchaki, 1040–1105) famously asks why the word nefesh is uniquely used here instead of the standard adam (man). He explains that the Minchah—made of inexpensive flour and oil—is typically brought by an ani (poor person). Hashem says, "I account it to him as if he offered his very soul." Let's be honest: not everyone in the times of the Beis HaMikdash (Holy Temple) could afford to bring a prime rib. Some could only afford the biblical equivalent of a generic, off-brand soup cracker. Yet, the Torah assures us that the accountant in Shamayim (Heaven) values this humble crumb precisely because of the immense personal sacrifice it took to procure it. This leads us perfectly into another curious requirement found a few pesukim (verses) later. Vayikra 2:13 dictates, "With all your offerings you shall offer salt." The Ramban (Rabbi Moshe ben Nachman, 1194–1270) explains that salt represents a bris (covenant) of permanence, because salt preserves meat from decaying. So, how do these two concepts intersect? The wealthy man brings a massive, expensive bull, but perhaps he does it while checking his ancient Rolex, eager to get back to his business. The poor man brings a handful of flour. But when that flour is mixed with the "salt" of absolute, enduring commitment—the Bris Melach—it outshines the gold. Hashem isn't looking to open a celestial steakhouse; He desires the nefesh, the permanence of our connection, no matter how unglamorous the physical offering looks.

Practical Takeaway: We don't have a physical Mizbeach (altar) today, but we certainly have our daily grind. We often think that to serve Hashem properly, we need to make grand, expensive gestures—like sponsoring a building wing or finishing all of Shas (the Talmud) by next Tuesday. But real life is usually a Korban Minchah. It's the flour-and-oil moments: choosing not to snap at your spouse when you're both exhausted, resisting the urge to critique the chazzan (cantor) who clearly thinks he's in a Broadway audition, or dragging yourself to a daf yomi (daily Talmud) shiur (class) when your brain feels like applesauce. Add a little salt—consistency and dedication—to those seemingly cheap, unglamorous moments, and Hashem considers it as if you've offered your very soul.

News & Simchos!

Regular Kiddush This Week
With Cholent, Kugel, and Short Shuir

All Previous Newsletters are
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Attention Gentlemen
Friday Mincha: 2:30 PM

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Shabbus Zmanim

Chestnut Ridge, NY

2:30 pm	מנחה
5:52/6:50 pm	הדלקה (Early/Late)
--- pm	מנחה - קבלת שבת
7:09 pm	שקיעה
5:35/5:45 am	עלות השחר (16.1/72)
6:57:44 am	נץ החמה
7:15 am	שחרית
Hot kiddush & Shiur after davening	
9:24/10:00 am	סיור קריאת שמע
10:37/11:01 am	סיור תפילה
1:03:23 pm	חצות היום
1:34:05 pm	מנחה גדולה (30)
4:37:01 pm	מנחה קטנה (גר"א)
5:53:14 pm	פלג המנחה (גר"א)
--- pm	מנחה
7:09 pm	שקיעה
7:50/7:59 pm	צה"כ ר' משה (8.5/50)
8:01 pm	מעריב (52)
8:09/8:21 pm	צה"כ (60/72)



Next Week's Zmanim

Chestnut Ridge, NY

2:30 pm	מנחה
6:58 pm	הדלקה
7:16 pm	שקיעה
7:15 am	שחרית
7:17 pm	שקיעה
8:09 pm	מעריב (52)

This Week's Riddle

Riddle: Where is honey mentioned in this parsha?

Answer: Honey cannot be offered on the Mizbeach (Vayikra 2:11).



Donations & Payments

Zelle: Send to 845-252-1260

Check: Write Out to Bais Midrash 715

Cash: Hand to Tzvi Zev or Adam Edelstein

Credit Card: Ask Tzvi Zev Rubin for a link

Gift Card/Bitcoin: Do we look like Indian Scammers to you?

משל ונמשל ב-א תאמין?

By Reb Gemini

Mashal: Imagine our dear friend, Reb Berel, a man who appreciates a good bargain almost as much as he appreciates a hot potato kugel (pudding). One day, he decides to donate a magnificent, gold-embroidered paroches (ark curtain) to the shul (synagogue). The congregation is astounded; it's an absolute masterpiece. However, a few weeks later, the shul's Gabbai (sexton) gets a frantic phone call. It turns out Reb Berel bought the luxurious fabric from a rather shady warehouse and, in a moment of rationalized brilliance, paid for it using a "creative" interpretation of the tax code and funds he "temporarily diverted" from his business partner's account. He figured, "It's for the shul, so the ends obviously justify the means!" When the truth comes out, the Rav (Rabbi) immediately orders the paroches taken down. You simply cannot wrap the holy Sifrei Torah (Torah scrolls) in a fabric woven with deceit. The external beauty of the donation is completely nullified if the internal mechanism of acquiring it was built on a foundation of gezet (theft). A stolen velvet curtain doesn't make you a tzaddik (righteous person); it just makes you a well-decorated thief.

Nimshal: This brings us to a fascinating detail in this week's parshah (weekly Torah portion), Parshas Vayikra. The Torah discusses the Korban Olah (elevation offering) brought from fowl, specifically turtledoves or young pigeons (Vayikra 1:14). When detailing the processing of this offering, the pasuk (verse) dictates that the Kohen (Priest) must remove the bird's crop and its feathers, casting them near the ashes beside the Mizbeach (altar). Rashi (Rabbi Shlomo Yitzchaki, 1040-1105), citing Vayikra Rabbah (3:4), asks a piercing question: Why, regarding an animal offering, does the Torah command that the innards be carefully washed and offered on the altar, whereas for a bird, the digestive organs are essentially thrown into the trash? Rashi explains that a domesticated animal eats from the crib of its owner; its food is honestly acquired. A bird, however, flies freely, swooping down to snatch seeds and insects from anyone's private property. Its crop is filled with gezet. Hashem commands that this organ be ripped out and entirely discarded. The Ribono Shel Olam (Master of the Universe) is sending a clear, unequivocal message: He does not want anything associated with theft on His holy altar, no matter how pure the intentions of the person bringing the korban (sacrifice) might be.

Practical Takeaway: The practical takeaway is a sobering reminder that Yiddishkeit (Judaism) does not operate on a Robin Hood philosophy. We often find ourselves trying to bring a beautiful "offering" to Hashem while completely ignoring the unsavory "crop" that facilitated it. Perhaps it's staying up until two in the morning learning Gemara (Talmud), only to sleep through Shacharis (morning prayers) and bark at our children because we are utterly exhausted. Or maybe it's the classic maneuver of aggressively cutting someone off in the synagogue parking lot just to make absolutely sure we don't miss Barchu (the call to prayer). We try to hand Hashem a beautiful bird, but He is looking straight at the crop. Real avodas Hashem (service of God) demands honesty in the mundane, seemingly insignificant details of our daily interactions. This week, before you attempt a grand spiritual gesture, make sure the basic mechanics of your bein adam lachaveiro (interpersonal relationships) are clean. Let us strive to ensure that our spiritual offerings are entirely our own, free of any borrowed coats or forcefully acquired honors, so they may truly be a rei'ach nichoach (pleasing aroma) before Hashem.

GOOD SHABBUS!